

products you see on their site. They have instead brought on board various other sellers. This model was originally seen on eBay and is now adopted by pretty much every popular e-commerce site.

One of the biggest advantages of such a system is that it opens up the possibility of selecting whatever you'd want to buy from the largest selection possible. eBay currently has close to 30,000 resellers on-board, which means that if you're looking for an HDMI cable, chances are that you'd find every kind of cable in existence through one seller or another. Now try hunting for that in your local market.

Once you've taken care of the above two pointers, don't think it ends there. There are a few more important things one must keep in mind.

Once You're Ready to Buy Research your deals

The whole point of buying online is that we can find better deals faster and more conveniently. Back in the day of analogue, people would scour markets, looking up prices on the one thing they wanted to buy. We suggest going through the popular e-commerce sites to find a good deal on the products you're trying to purchase. You're chilling on your chair anyway, so how much effort could it be to open a few extra browser tabs? Not a lot. However one strong word of caution. If you find the stuff you're looking for on a relatively new/obscure e-commerce site, we strongly recommend staying away from that deal. In the online transaction



Don't just shell out your cash willy-nilly. Understand how transactions work on the site you're purchasing from.

world, the simple rule is "if it's too good to be true, it probably is."

Pick the right seller:

Each of the e-commerce sites will have a particular seller that offers the best service. This is where your free time and internet skills come in. You ideally want to buy from a seller who'd take good care of you in the event your order goes wrong. Look at the negative ratings, and it will give you a good idea of where the seller falters. We don't mean to sound like we're endorsing the brand, but if you want a hassle free online shopping

experience, products from Amazon.in that carry the "fulfilled by Amazon" tag are probably the most reliable. These products are guaranteed by Amazon to be available and will be delivered to you by the requisite date, no matter what, free of charge (on orders less than Rs. 500). These products are also tested at Amazon's fulfillment centres for quality.

We reached out to various online retailers and the spokesperson from Amazon and eBay India informed us that one of the best ways to ensure that your purchase isn't going to end up being a headache is by ensuring that you're only buying from sellers that have a very high positive rating.

Mode of payment:

While CoD ensures that none of your cash goes into a transaction that could eventually go sour, paying by Credit Card or Debit Card is also a safe bet. If an online retailer can't process your order, the money is simply returned to your account, though in the case of a credit card transaction, it may take a few days, depending on your bank. Your money is safe in the event the order doesn't go through, as long as you are ordering from a reputed online marketplace.

eBay India has implemented PaisaPay, a payment method which holds the money until the order reaches the customer. In fact, if the package isn't shipped within five days of placing the order, the money is automatically refunded.

After You've Bought: Track, Track, TRACK!

As we learnt from our recent experience, the first signs of a cancelled order lie in the order status remaining as "processing" for any duration longer than 2 business days. eBay gives its sellers five days to update the order information, but if your order has been "processing" for longer than that, call up the customer care helpline and get one of them to verify the status of your order. If they are going to come through with your shipment, they will tell you so and if not, they will probably say something like "we're still trying to procure your order," or something similar. If your order status hasn't moved after 2 days of this call, you're better off cancelling the order, but the final call is still yours.

